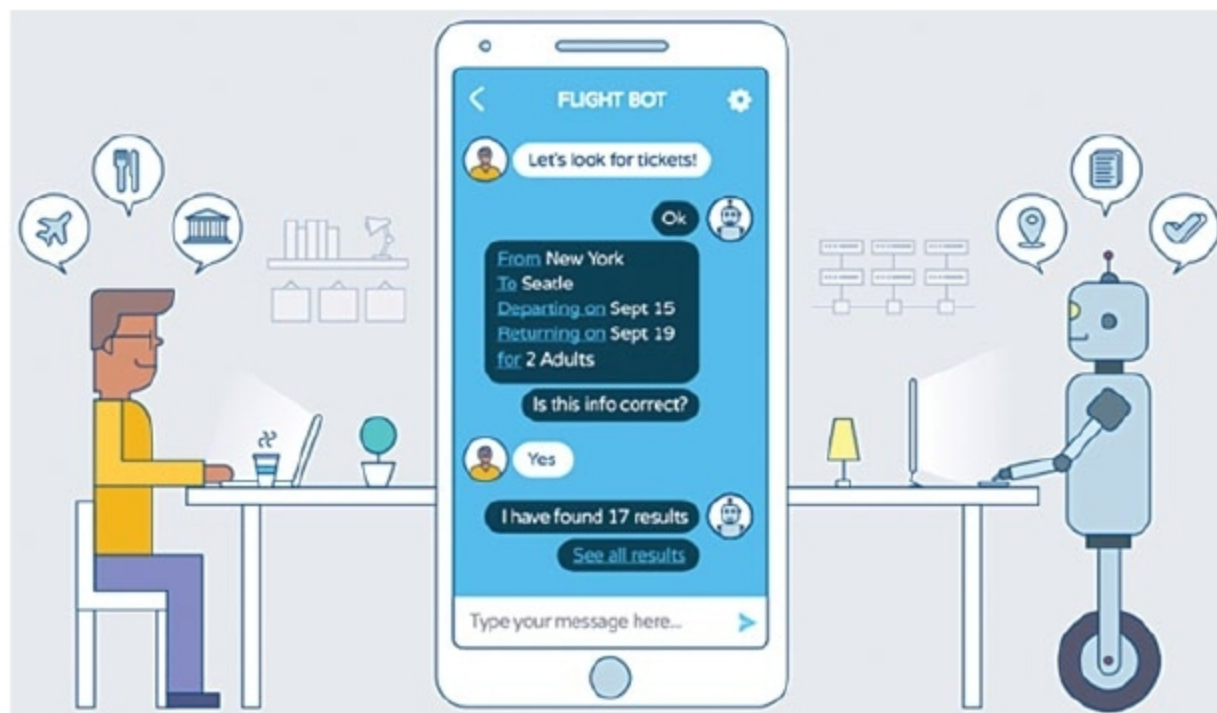




Chatbots of the future (Credit: <https://medium.com>)

from Robotics Tomorrow, Aircraft Tooling, a Texas-based repair centre for the aviation industry, has been operating Universal Robots cobots (collaborative robots) in high temperatures and harsh environments for performing metal powder and plasma spray processes for three years without breakdown or service requirements.

Along with usefulness, more and more people are opting for sustainable options. In 2019, Unilever announced that its sustainable living brands were growing 69 per cent faster than the rest of the business and delivering 75 per cent of the company's growth. To meet its goal of sending zero waste to landfills, Whirlpool uses the IoT and analytics platforms to get information about total waste generated and sustainability performance of its facilities globally.

The road ahead

According to a report from Capgemini Research Institute titled 'Smart Factories @ Scale,' China, Germany and Japan lead in adoption of smart factories. In India, Department of Heavy Industry (DHI) and Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) have launched numerous schemes to avoid threats to the domestic manufacturing share and promote smart manufacturing.

SAMARTH-Udyog Bharat 4.0, for example, is one such initiative by DHI under its scheme on the enhancement of competitiveness in the Indian capital goods sector. Most companies that planned to establish smart factories in

the nation have been successful.

Schneider Electric launched two smart factories in Hyderabad and Bengaluru in 2019. The factories exhibit how an IoT-enabled system architecture and platform can drive automation and increase operational efficiency while cutting expenses. With a huge population in the country, consumer opinion plays a huge role in large-scale implementation of smart manufacturing in the industry.

Yet, the biggest challenge in any ecosystem remains data security and privacy. IoT systems are vulnerable to security breaches and leaks that raise suspicion among customers. Also, many organisations are afraid to move to newer technologies, platforms and applications. Companies that have invested heavily in on-premises platforms have to cope with the task of moving more functionality to the cloud.

To integrate systems and enable data sharing across them, well-defined standards and protocols are required. Global manufacturers must be aware of legal compliances in different countries where they operate while implementing changes. Talent shortage, especially for data scientist and business analyst roles, is another issue in many places for which reskilling/upskilling is necessary.

In spite of these challenges, smart industries are here to stay. So, if you are not transitioning already, it is time to reconnect with your consumers by hopping on board the Industry 4.0 bandwagon and stay relevant. **EFY**

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